Empiricism

John Locke and David Hume

1. Key idea of empiricism – Pages 1
2. Locke on the origin of ideas. - Pages 2-4
3. Locke against innate ideas. - Pages 4-5
4. David Hume on the origins of knowledge. - Pages 6-8
5. Hume on simple and complex ideas. - Pages 8-9
6. The missing shade of blue. - Pages 10-11
7. Empiricists of substance. - Pages 11-14
8. Empiricists on God. - Pages 14-15
9. Empiricists on external world. - Pages 15-16
10. Glossary – pages 16

Empiricism is the epistemological thesis, that knowledge is split into two categories, knowledge of relations of ideas, and knowledge of matters of fact. The first, 'relations of ideas' can be known by attending to the ideas, without need to consider anything in the world. For example, I can know that all bachelors are unmarried men, by simply considering the meaning of the terms. As regards matters of fact, this is knowledge of how things are in the world, and given that things in the world are contingent, these can only be known by reference to experience or sense data. We cannot know truths about the world, with reason alone.

There are two questions which we will consider. Firstly, the origins of our knowledge and secondly, the origins of our ideas. This handout will make sure to refer much of the discussion to knowledge of the self, God and the world, so that we can compare empiricism, to the work of rationalists such as Descartes and Leibniz.

John Locke: An essay concerning human understanding.

John Locke proposes arguments against the idea of innate knowledge and the idea of innate concepts. We shall look at these in turn. Later on we shall consider how David Hume took up and developed Locke's project.

John Locke's argument against innate knowledge and ideas.

Locke considers the rationalist claim that all people are born with knowledge of some very basic principles, such as 'what is, is' or 'it is impossible for the same thing to be and not to be'. So, for example, the claim that *all people* know that 'what exists, exists' or that 'something can't exist and not exist at the same time'. For rationalists, universal knowledge of these principles prove the existence of innate knowledge.
Locke claims that this argument cannot work. He draws on the distinction between the fact that *human beings might act in accordance with those beliefs* (in this sense they accept them), but that is *not the same as knowing them*. His argument can be put as follows,

Locke's argument against innate knowledge

If innate knowledge existed it would be something *everyone* has (it would be *universal*). 'principles…universally agreed upon by all mankind: which therefore, they argue, must needs be the constant impressions which the souls of men receive in their first beings, and which they bring into the world with them…'
Second, for knowledge of principles to be part of the mind people must be *conscious* of those principles, 'it seems nearly a contradiction to say that there are truths

imprinted on the soul that it does not perceive of understand. No proposition could be said to be in the mind which it has never known or been conscious of.'

People who are cognitively undeveloped including children and babies, do not understand these principles, 'for example that it is impossible for something to exist and not exist' and therefore they do not know them. 'For first, it is evident, that all children and idiots have not the least apprehension or thought of them'.

So, for there to be innate knowledge,

(1) everyone must have it.

(2) Everyone must be conscious of it.

Now, if some people do not know these principles which are regarded as innate, then there is no innate knowledge. This is what Locke will in fact claim.

Locke considers the response that is often made by rationalists that innate knowledge of basic ideas such as 'what is, is' is known *after people come to use reason*. He writes that

> 'It is usually answered that all men know and assent to them, after *they come to the use of reason*; and that is enough to prove them innate.'

Locke thinks that this answer is clearly unsatisfactory, because if we needed reason to come to these principles, we would discover these principles which means at one point we did not know them. 'That certainly can never be thought innate which we have need of reason to discover...'

Secondly, he notes that these principles themselves, enable reason to function at all. For example, the idea that 'something cannot exist and not exist' is a principle without

which reason cannot function. Which means reason cannot uncover them, but rather must presuppose them to function.

Finally, he also considers the argument that knowledge of these principles is self-evident, and so innate, and whether this proves the existence of innate knowledge. Locke points out that *if self-evidence at moment of understanding* was a mark of innate reason then we would have much more innate knowledge than the rationalists want to admit to. We would have to admit knowledge of mathematics as innate, for example that 2+2=4. He writes,

> 'For upon the same ground, viz, of assent at first hearing and understanding the terms, that men would have those maxims pass for innate, they must also admit several propositions about numbers to be innate;…that two and two are equal to four.'

Locke against innate ideas/concepts

Locke goes further and claims not only that humans do not have innate knowledge of principle but also of ideas, such as 'God', 'the soul' or 'impossibility' and 'possibility'. It is important to understand that for Locke innate concepts (like innate knowledge) are defined with two important ingredients, firstly, that innate concepts are universal, secondly, that all people are conscious of having those ideas. Locke gives three reasons to deny this claim.

Firstly, 'He who attentively considers the state of a child, at his first coming into the world, will have little reason to think him stored with plenty of ideas, that are to be the matter of his of his future knowledge'. Indeed, apart from the idea of heat and comfort it is unlikely that babies have any ideas at all.

Secondly, regarding innate knowledge of God, Locke takes this seriously because he thinks that it is one of the stronger arguments of the rationalists. He writes that 'I grant that if there were any idea to be imprinted on the minds of men, we have reason to expect it should be the notion of his Maker, as a mark God set on his own workmanship..' However, Locke points to the fact that some nations or cultures did not have an idea of God, and also that it is an idea that often needs to be taught to the young. He writes, 'But how late is it before any such notion is to be discoverable in children? And when we find it there how much more does it resemble the opinion and notion of the teacher, then represent the true God?' Then speaking of other cultures he writes, 'what true or tolerable notion of a Deity could they have, who acknowledged and worshipped hundreds' (of deities)? Clearly there are some cultures that either are so polytheist and thus have no idea of God, or even some atheist sects. Finally, Locke claims that the only way for an idea to be lodged in the mind, without us at one and the same time being aware of it, is via the memory. However, to remember something means that one is conscious of a past experience of it, and that means that one must have experience of it first, so these ideas are not innate.

How do empiricists explain the origins of ideas and knowledge in the mind?

Given that empiricists do not accept the rationalist account of how ideas and knowledge are found in the mind, Locke develops the core thesis of empiricism, *that all knowledge and ideas are the result of experience, specifically sense experience and reflection*. For Lock, the mind can be understood as a 'tabula rasa' (a blank slate that children would write on at school), the claim being that our minds start out empty, until an impression is made on it, from the outside. Locke writes

> 'Let us suppose the mind to be, as we say, white paper, void of all characters, without any ideas: - How comes it to be furnished? Whence comes it by that

> vast store which the busy and boundless fancy of a man has painted on it with an almost endless variety? When has it all the materials of reason and knowledge? To this I answer, in one word, from EXPERIENCE.' Locke

Locke then claims that all our knowledge of ideas must come from two types of experience. Experience is observation of either 'external objects' in the world, or internal 'operations of our mind'. The former can be called *sensation* and the latter *reflection*.

Of sensation Locke writes that 'First, our Senses, conversant about particular sensible objects, do convey into the mind several distinct perceptions of things, according to those various ways wherein those objects do affect them. And thus we come by those ideas we have of *yellow, white, heat, cold, soft, hard, bitter, sweet,* and all those which we call sensible qualities.' In other words, we have experiences that our senses pass to us of objects in the external world, these give us knowledge and ideas.

Secondly, we have experiences of reflection, these are 'perceptions of the operations of our own mind within us.' And 'this REFLECTION, the ideas it affords being such only as the mind gets by reflecting on its own operations with itself.' Reflection provides the ideas of thinking, willing and feeling.

Experience	Objects
Experience of sensation	The objects of the external world
Experience of reflection	The operations and objects of the mind and the internal world.

David Hume: An enquiry concerning human understanding

David Hume kept the basic structure of Locke's empiricism, however, he did use a slightly different terminology in his theory. There will now be a list of technical terms as Hume understood them.

Perceptions: Perceptions are *anything* before the mind, that we are immediately aware of. For example, seeing a flower, imagining a flower, feeling hungry, thinking about Paris.

Impressions: Impressions are forceful, lively and vivacious perceptions. We can have impressions of sensation and impression of reflection. The experience of a bright red colour is an impression.

Ideas: Ideas are *copies of impressions*, they are less forceful, lively and vivacious, and ideas can only exist because of impressions.

Sensations: These are impressions that originate in the external world. For example, seeing a fire.

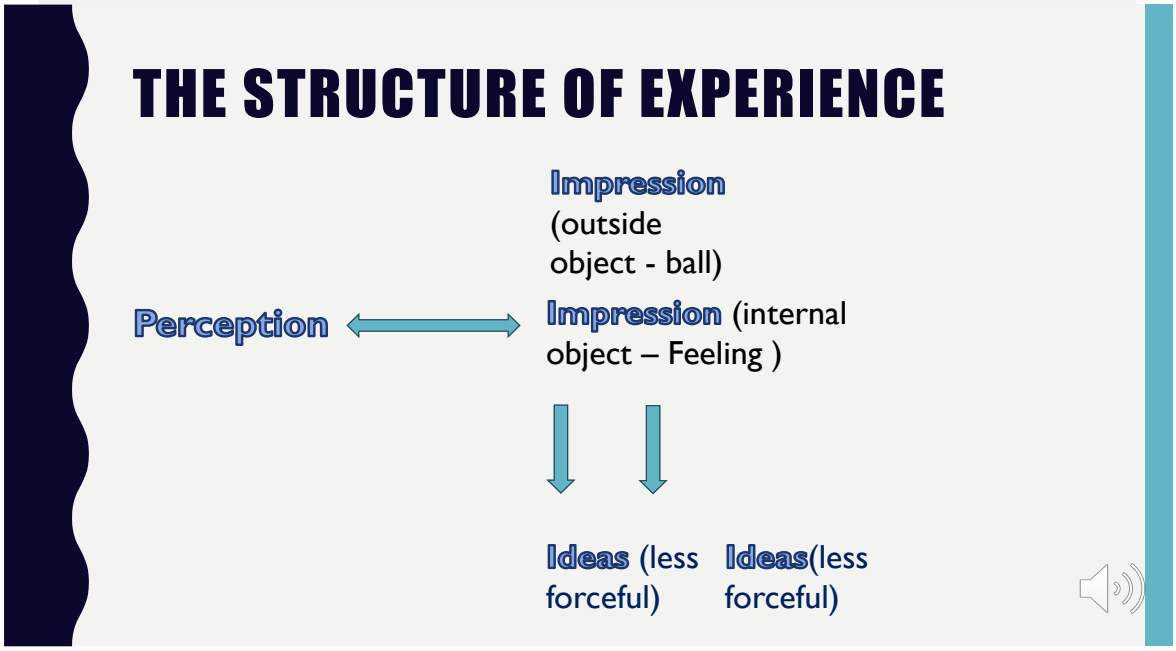
Reflection: These are impressions of caused by looking in on the mind. For example, feeling warm.

Hume divides perceptions into two classes, which he distinguished by their force and vivacity. He writes,

> *'Here therefore we may divide all perceptions of the mind into two classes or species, which are distinguished by their different degrees of force and vivacity. The less forcible and lively are commonly denominated THOUGHTS or IDEAS. The other species (we will call) IMPRESSIONS.'*

We can think of impressions as an experience of listening to live music, this is forceful, lively and vivacious. If, however, after several weeks we think back to our experience of the music it is a less lively, and less vivid, copy of the original experience.

> *'Everyone can readily agree that there is a considerable difference between the perceptions of the mind, when a man feels the pain of excessive heat, or the pleasure of moderate warmth, and when he afterwards recalls to his memory this sensation, or anticipates it by his imagination. These faculties may mimic or copy the perceptions of the senses, but they can never entirely reach the force and vivacity of the original sentiment.'*



Simple and Complex ideas

Hume divides all impressions and idea into two categories, 'simple' and 'complex' ideas. Simple ideas can be thought of ideas 'such as admit of no distinction nor separation.' So, for example, the colour yellow would be a simple idea. A complex idea would for example be an apple, which has many simple ideas combined. An

apple has a round shape, it has a specific colour for example it is red, it is sweet, it is has a certain weight. Hume says of complex ideas that,

> 'The complex…may be distinguished into parts. Tho' a particular colour, taste, and smell are qualities all united together in this apple, 'tis easy to perceive they are not the same, but are at least distinguishable from each other.'

One important question that Hume would need to answer, is how human beings are able to have ideas of things that have never been experienced. Thus, how is it that we have the idea of fairies or of aliens, if we need experiences of objects to have ideas. The answer can be found in the mechanics of the mind. The mind is able to do three important things. It can,

(1) We can unite or combine the impressions into new ideas.
(2) We can also form complex concepts by abstraction.
(3) We can put together simple concepts in an original way.

The mechanism of the mind	The ideas
We can unite of combine the impressions into new ideas.	In this example we see a complex set of ideas as one thing say a dog.
We can also form a complex or general concepts by abstraction.	We can also see several different types of dog and form the abstract and 'general' idea of a dog.
We can put together simple concepts in an original way.	Or we can take different set of ideas from our previous experience and combine them in new ways. I can for

	example combine a horse with wings and call create the idea of Pegasus.

The missing shade of blue thought experiment.

Hume considered a possible problem with the copy principle in is work, 'A treatise of human nature'. If it can be shown that an idea can enter the mind without previous experience, we may be able to debunk the theory. Hume considers the following thought experiment,

> 'There is, however, one contradictory phenomenon, which may prove, that it is not absolutely impossible for ideas to arise, independent of their corresponding impressions. I believe it will readily be allowed, that the several distinct ideas of colour, which enter by the eye, or those of sound, which are conveyed by the ear, are really different from each other; though, at the same time, resembling. Now if this be true of different colours, it must be no less so of the different shades of the same colour; and each shade produces a distinct idea, independent of the rest…Suppose, therefore, a person to have enjoyed sight for thirty years, and to have become perfectly acquainted with the colours of all kinds, except one particular shade of blue, for instance, which it never has been his fortune to meet with. Let all the different shades of that colour, except that single one, be placed before him, descending gradually from the deepest to the lightest; it is plain, that he will perceive a blank, where that shade is wanting, and will be sensible, that there is a greater distance in that place between the contiguous colours than in any other. Now I ask, whether it be possible for him, from his own imagination, to supply this deficiency, and raise up to himself the idea of that particular shade though it

> had never been conveyed to him by his senses? I believe there are few but will be of the opinion that he can:'

Hume, however, thinks that this example is so unique, that he does it enough to overthrow his theory.

Another defence is to say that if we have similar ideas that are very close to the idea we have not experienced, we do have the ability using imagination to augment or diminish the intensity of an idea, and thus bring to mind, a hue of colour, similar to one we are already familiar with, but have never experienced.

Empiricism on 'Substance', 'God' and 'the external world'.

We will now consider how empiricism explains the origin of our knowledge of Self/substance, God and the external world, in order to contrast it with rationalist theories.

Hume and Berkeley on substance and the self

A good example of how empiricism differs from rationalism is how Berkeley and Hume understand the origins of the idea of substance, and the self.

Berkeley was one of the first philosophers to question the coherence of the idea of substance. Remember a substance is that thing which stays the same while its properties change, and Descartes thought we could 'rationally intuit' the idea of substance by thinking of how a piece of wax can change all its properties but remain identical over time. Berkeley points out that if we take away all the properties of a supposed external object, such as colour, weight, shape and extension, nothing will be left over and so the idea of substance is confused. In other words, if the idea of

substance is to make sense, we must be able to have an experience of it, not just an understanding of it. Since we cannot have an experience of it, it does not exist.

> 'By 'matter' therefore we are to understand an inert, senseless substances, in which extension, figure, and motion do actually subsist. But it is evident from what we have already shown that extension, figure and motion are only ideas existing in the mind, and that an idea can be like nothing but another idea, and that consequently neither they nor their archetypes can exist in an unperceiving substance. Hence it is plain that the very notion of what is called 'matter', or 'corporeal substance' involves a contradiction in it.'

Although Berkeley thought the idea of 'substance' was confused, he did think that the idea of the self was coherent. This was because we had an idea of the mind as active, when it perceives, desires and thinks. Although, as an empiricist, Berkeley thought our idea of self, is derived from our experience of self, and was not known innately.

David Hume was even more sceptical about the coherence of the idea of substance, he not only applied Berkeley's argument, to the idea of external objects, but he also applied it to the idea of a mental substance. Hume notes that experience only gives evidence for *qualitative* identity and not *numerical* identity. Qualitative identity, is the identity we find between two can of coca cola, i.e. the appear identical. Numerical identity is found between one can of coca cola, and itself over time.
Hume's claim, is that for example, if I look at a football on the ground, and then look away from it and return to look at it a minute later, all I have evidence of is that the ball I saw and the ball I am not seeing *look exactly the same*, but not that they *are* exactly the same. My mind, works using its power or vividness and association to

assume the two are numerically identical. The problem is that we never see identity as an idea, we only assume it, much like causation. The same claim can be applied to mental substance. We only ever experience a stream of ideas, thoughts and feelings, not what makes them all the thoughts and feelings of the same thing. Hume thinks the mind has good reason to do this. However, the main issue is that Hume thinks that the use of this notion is confused, because we have no clear idea of what we mean by numerical identity. Hume in the Treatise writes that,

> 'I would fain ask those philosophers…whether the ideas of *substance* be derived from the impressions of sensation or reflexion? If it be conveyed to us by our senses, I ask, which of them; and after what manner? If it be perceived by the eyes, it must be a colour; of by the ears; it must be a sound; if by the palate, a taste; and so of the other senses. But I believe none will assert, that substance is either, a colour, or a sound or a taste. The idea of substance must therefore be derived from an impression of reflexion, if it really exist. But the impressions of reflexion resolve themselves into our passions and emotions, none of which can possibly represent a substance. We have therefor no idea of substance, distinct from that of a collection of particular qualities, nor have we any other meaning when we either talk or reason concerning it.'

Hume's attack on the coherence of a separate mental substance as self can be found in the following quotation from the Treatise.

> 'There are some philosophers who imagine we are every moment intimately conscious of what we call our SELF; that we feel its existence and continuance in existence; and are certain, beyond the evidence of demonstration, both of its perfect identity and simplicity.'

Then he writes,

> ''Unluckily all these positive assertions are contrary to that very experience, which is pleaded for them, nor have we any idea of *self,* after the manner it is here explained, for from what impression could this idea be derived? …But the self is not any one impression, but that to which our several impressions and ideas are supposed to have a reference'.

Here Hume is claiming that for an idea to be coherent we must have some very clear impression of it in our mind, however, we have no impression of the self as the same thing over time, or any impression of it at all. For Hume the self is a name that is attached to a bundle of every changing elements that never stay the same. We could think of this with the analogy of a 'government' or 'republic' that has a name, but does not keep any one thing the same over time.

Empiricism on the idea of God

Descartes will argue for the existence of God from a priori reasoning, and what he considers to be innate ideas. For Hume the idea of God has other origins. It is important to remind ourselves of the three processes the mind has available to it, with which it can manipulate ideas. As we noted earlier the imagination can compound, transpose, augment or diminish ideas that it has available to it. Hume writes *'To form monsters, and join incongruous shapes and appearances, costs the imagination no more trouble than to conceive the most natural and familiar objects'*. As regards God, all the human imagination need do, is take a human quality and augment it beyond limit, for example, justice, beauty, power or intelligence. Thus he claims that,

> ‘The idea of God as meaning an infinitely intelligent, wise, and good Being, arises from reflecting on the operations of our own mind, and augmenting without limit those qualities of goodness, and wisdom.’

And more problematically for Hume and against Descartes, we find in Descartes two contradictory beliefs, first that we have a clear and distinct idea of God, and also that God is beyond human grasp and comprehension, which seems to undermine Descartes claim.

Empiricism and proof of the external world

Berkeley denies the existence of the external world, and claimed that the very idea of an external object that causes our senses experience is a confusion. Hume would have denied that we can know *a priori* that external objects exist, and that are the cause of our sense experiences. This is because, we cannot, and have never seen, anything beyond our sense data. Russell and Locke thought that the best arguments for the existence of the external world, were inference to the best explanation, in other words, although we could not prove the existence of the external world, our best hypothesis gave us good reason to believe in the existence of the external world. All of these are of course, consistent with the claim that empiricism naturally leads to scepticism about the existence of the external world, it may be that empiricism, as a doctrine, will in all likelihood suffer from that weakness. However, without belief in God, Descartes rationalist arguments are hopeless, and so empiricism in the final analysis gives a better account of what we can know. Of the idea of external objects Hume writes

> ‘The farthest we can go towards a conception of external objects, when supposed *specifically* different from our perceptions, is to form a relative idea

of them, without pretending to comprehend the related objects. Generally speaking we do not suppose them specifically different; but only attribute to them different relations, connexions and durations.'

In other word, our idea of external objects are at best derived from our ideas of internal perceptions, and these we cannot really 'pretend to comprehend'.

Glossary

Innate – That which comes from the womb – i.e. something we are born with.

Inference to the best explanation – The best hypothesis available among a number of hypotheses, to explain a fact.

Matters of fact – States of affairs in the world, that are contingent. For example, it is 10C today.

Relation of ideas – How two ideas are related to each other. For example, a triangle and its internal angles.

Substance – That which stays the same while its properties change. The substance can exist without the properties, but the properties cannot exist without the substance.